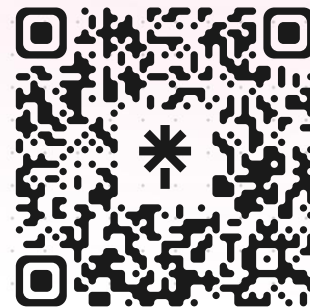


Copilot Cowork Masterclass

Hands-On with Your AI Coworker

April Dunnam



Today's Agenda

01

The AI Tool Landscape

Where Cowork fits among your AI tools

02

Meet Your AI Coworker

What Cowork is, plus your first challenge

03

Everyday Productivity

Ways to incorporate Cowork into your day to day

04

Build & Extend Cowork

Skills, plugins, and automation

05

Labs + Your Action Plan

Hands-on challenges, resources & Q&A

RUN OF SHOW

Four hours, hands-on

Times are elapsed from start · two 15-minute breaks · bring your own M365 tenant with Cowork

PART 1 · Foundations

0:00 – 1:05

Welcome & opening poll
The AI Tool Landscape
Meet Your AI Coworker
Should You Cowork?
+ Demo + Challenge 1



BREAK · 15 MIN

PART 2 · Do the Work

1:20 – 2:20

Everyday Productivity +
Demo + Challenge 2
Build Your Own: Skills +
Demos + Challenges 3 & 4
...Scheduled Tasks + demo



BREAK · 15 MIN

PART 3 · Extend & Apply

2:35 – 4:00

Plugins, MCP & Browser (preview)
Tips, Licensing & Pop Quiz
Cowork Labs
Wrap, Q&A & Resources

Live audience poll

Let's get to know each other

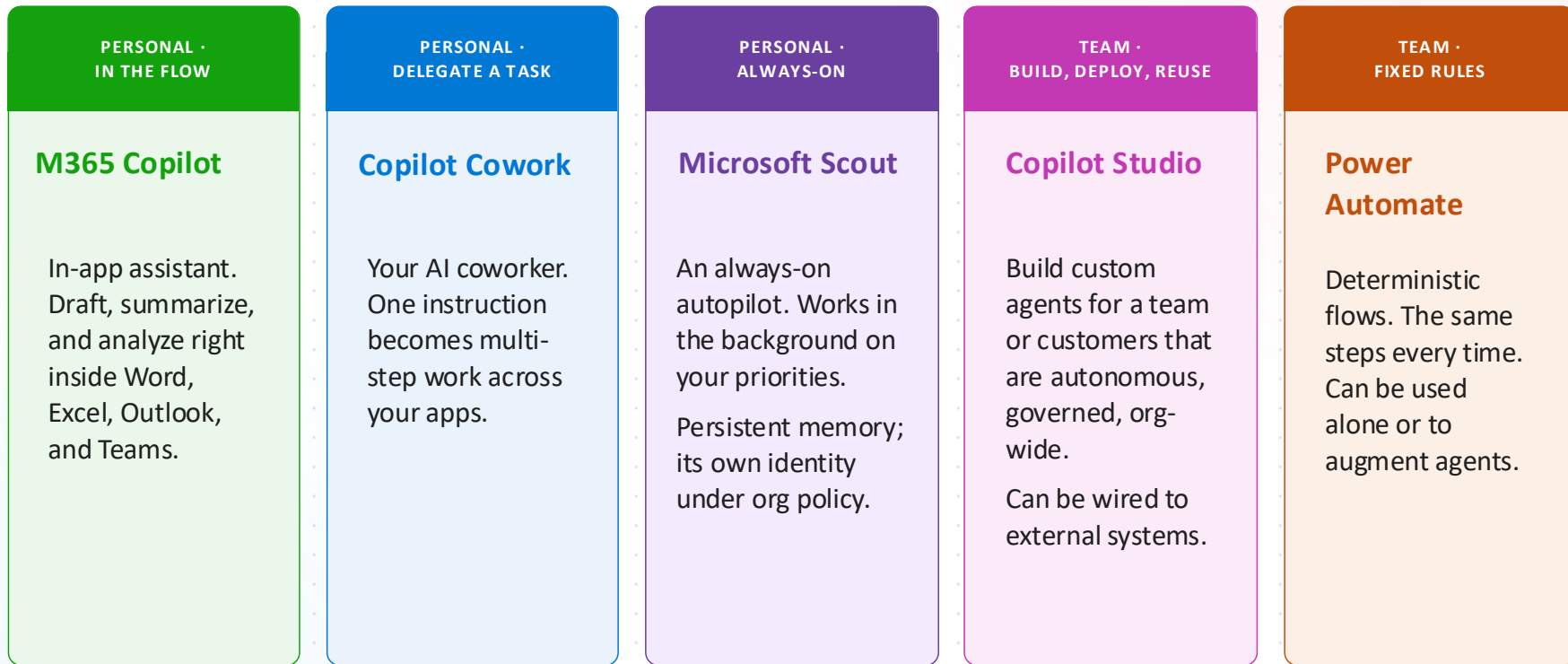
01

SECTION

The AI Tool Landscape

Where Copilot Cowork fits among your AI tools

The AI Tool Landscape: Personal vs Team



Copilot Cowork lives in the PERSONAL layer. It works for you, not the whole org.

So, what is Copilot Cowork?

You describe the outcome; it figures out the how.

Your AI coworker in M365

- Delegate outcomes in plain language; it plans and does the work.
- Lives at `m365.cloud.microsoft`, plus desktop and mobile apps.
- Built on Anthropic's Claude models.

Acts across your apps

- Outlook, Teams, SharePoint, OneDrive, and Office in one session.
- Creates Word, Excel, PowerPoint, PDFs, and images.

Works on your terms

- Previews sensitive actions for your approval first.
- Runs on-demand or on a schedule; inherits your permissions.
- No data leaves your Microsoft compliance boundary.

WHERE IT COMES FROM

Built on Claude, with M365 Integration

Copilot Cowork is Microsoft's enterprise take on Anthropic's Claude Cowork.

Claude Cowork

Anthropic's original

Runs on your own device

- A great general-purpose agent
- Works with local files and the web
- Lives outside M365 governance
- Personal / consumer roots
- Files stored locally by default

Copilot Cowork

the M365-native version

Runs in the Microsoft cloud

- Grounded in your Work IQ + M365 data
- Acts across Outlook, Teams, SharePoint
- Inside Purview, DLP & Conditional Access
- Supports multiple models
- Files saved to OneDrive / SharePoint

Same Cowork idea but re-homed inside your enterprise boundary.

What Copilot Cowork adds over Claude Cowork

Same Cowork engine underneath, plus the three things only Microsoft brings.

Work IQ

- Grounded in your Microsoft Data (people, files, meetings, chats and org).
- Reasons over your real work, not just what you paste into a chat.
- More work context in, more complete and accurate results out.

Native to the Microsoft stack

- Runs in your tenant under Entra ID, DLP, and compliance policies.
- Honors the permissions you already have and nothing more.
- Your data stays inside your Microsoft 365 boundary.

Model choice

- Pick Anthropic's Claude or OpenAI's GPT per task.
- Or leave it on Auto to balance quality, speed, and cost.
- New models drop in as they ship, no upgrade, no waiting.

NOT LOCKED TO ONE MODEL

Your choice of Claude or GPT Models

Two model families

- Cowork runs Anthropic's Claude models AND OpenAI's GPT models side by side.
- Most AI tools lock you into one family. Cowork doesn't.
- Switch per task, right from the chat header.

Leave it on Auto

- Cowork picks the best model for each task automatically.
- A great default because it balances capability, speed, and cost.

Or choose yourself

- Need deep reasoning? Pick a heavy model. Simple task? Pick an efficient one. You control the cost/quality trade-off.
- New models are added as they're released.

PICK THE RIGHT ENGINE

Which model and what it costs

MODEL	BEST FOR — USE WHEN	SPEED	COST
Auto	Default for mixed, multi-step jobs. It picks the right model per task	Varies	\$—\$\$
Claude Sonnet 5	Everyday drafting, summaries, triage, bulk edits. Offers the best value	Fast	\$ ~\$4
Claude Opus 4.8	Complex reasoning & polished, high-stakes deliverables	Moderate	\$\$ ~\$5
Claude Opus 5	Newest top-tier Claude model. Use for the hardest, highest-stakes work	Moderate	\$\$\$
GPT-5.6 Sol	OpenAI's most capable model. Use for deep, complex non-Claude tasks	Slower	\$\$\$
GPT-5.6 Terra	High-volume work. Solid quality, cheaper than Sol	Fast	\$\$
GPT-5.5	Dependable general GPT model. Good for long-form, citation-heavy, big context	Slow	\$\$\$ ~\$11

Runs on Copilot Credits (~\$0.01 each). Same task, different model = a very different bill — one test ran ~\$4 on Sonnet vs ~\$11 on GPT-5.5. Start on Auto, drop to Sonnet to save, and turn repeat tasks into Skills to cut credits further.



02

Meet Your AI Coworker

Understanding the shift from AI tools to AI coworkers

LET'S BUST A MYTH

“Cowork is the one that takes action”

You hear this everywhere. It's not quite right and it undersells what Cowork actually does.

THE MYTH

what everyone says

“Cowork takes action, Copilot just chats.”

- But M365 Copilot takes actions too...
- “Create this deck” → it builds the deck
- “Draft this email” → it drafts (and can send)
- “Build me an Excel” → it makes the file
- So “taking an action” isn't the difference

THE REALITY

what actually sets it apart

It's multi-step orchestration, not one action

- One instruction → a chain of many steps
- Reasons across several apps at once
- Holds context the whole way through
- Runs long, or on a schedule, on its own
- Copilot does a step; Cowork runs the job

The magic isn't that it acts, it's that it plans and chains many actions from one ask.

THE REAL DIFFERENCE

Cowork vs. M365 Copilot: what changes

Same M365 data. A very different amount of work per instruction.

M365 Copilot

in the flow of work

Great at single-step help

- Works inside one app at a time
- One turn: you prompt, it responds
- You chain the steps yourself
- You send, post, and schedule manually
- No memory of a task across apps

Copilot Cowork

your delegated coworker

Owens the whole multi-step job

- Works across Outlook, Teams, SharePoint at once
- One instruction → a full chain of steps
- It plans and sequences the work for you
- Drafts, files, and schedules (with approval)
- Holds context across apps and turns

Rule of thumb: a one-liner? Use Copilot. A whole job across apps? Delegate to Cowork.

The Mindset Shift

From "AI tool I prompt" to "AI coworker I delegate to"

Crafting the perfect prompt



Describing what you need done

One app at a time



Cross-app workflows

Manual follow-up



Scheduled automation

Generic outputs



Personalized to your data

Common Misconceptions

"I need to be technical"

It's natural language. If you can describe what you need, you can use Cowork

"It's just a chatbot"

It takes real actions, sends emails, schedules meetings, creates documents

"I need prompt engineering"

Focus on what to delegate, not how to perfectly phrase it. Cowork figures out the how

"It can't handle complex tasks"

It orchestrates multi-step workflows across your entire M365 environment

What is a Skill?

A saved playbook

- A skill is a reusable set of instructions that provide a saved way of doing a task.
- Written in plain language, no code, like a note you'd hand a new teammate.
- Cowork loads it only when the task matches.

Why it matters

- More efficient. Avoids having to re-prompt the same instructions
- Consistent output every time: your format, your rules.
- Saves \$\$

The M365 Copilot difference

- M365 Copilot answers a prompt. Cowork can CALL a skill, so complex, repeatable work runs the same way, hands-off.
- This is what turns Cowork from a chatbot into a coworker.

Copilot Cowork Comes With Out of the Box Skills

Core Productivity & M365

Word — Create & edit Word documents

Excel — Create & edit spreadsheets

PowerPoint — Create & edit presentations

PDF — Read, create & manipulate PDFs

Communication & Coordination

Email — Compose, reply, manage drafts & attachments

Communications — Stakeholder messaging

Meetings — Meeting intelligence & prep

Scheduling — Find times, book rooms, schedule meetings

Calendar Management — Create & manage events

Personal Productivity

Daily Briefing — Generate daily summaries across calendar, email & Teams

Knowledge & Reasoning

Enterprise Search — Search across your organization

Deep Research — Multi-source research & synthesis

Skill & UI Layer

Skill Management — Create, edit & manage personal skills

Adaptive Cards — Structured, interactive responses

What's New in Cowork



Generally available June 16, 2026

Browser Use (Preview)

Cowork drives Edge to act on websites with your sign-ins to handle things like expenses, travel, forms

Multi-Model Picker

Pick Claude (Sonnet 5, Opus) or GPT (5.5, 5.6) or leave it on Auto to tune capability, speed & cost

Mobile Hand-off

Start a task on your phone; it finishes in the cloud even after you close the app

Usage-Based Credits

Runs on Copilot Credits (~\$0.01 each) atop your M365 Copilot license, with tenant spend limits

Also new: 9 partner plugins (Miro, monday.com, Harvey, LSEG & more) plus the Cowork CLI for your terminal

LIVE DEMO

Cowork in Action

"Prep me for my 2pm meeting"

Watch Cowork check your calendar, find attendee context,
pull relevant emails, summarize recent docs, and deliver a briefing

Anatomy of a Great Cowork Prompt

Four parts turn a vague ask into a reliable result:

1. Goal — the outcome you want, in one line
2. Sources — the files, people, or date range to use
3. Format — length, structure, tone, and where to save or post it
4. Boundary — what to preview or approve, and when to ask you

Real example

“For my 2pm with Contoso, build a briefing packet: last 6 months of email with them, prior notes, and 3 talking points. Save as a Word doc in /Meetings/. Preview before you create anything.”

CHALLENGE 1

Your First Cowork Conversation

Open Copilot Cowork and give it a real task from your workday

1. "What's on my calendar today and what should I prioritize?"
2. "Summarize the last 5 emails from [person] and tell me what needs my attention"
3. "Find the latest version of [document] and give me the key points"
4. "Check my Teams messages and flag anything I need to respond to"
5. "Prep me for my next meeting"

Goal

Experience the difference between a single-shot prompt and a multi-step, cross-app conversation with your AI coworker.

03

SECTION

Should You Cowork?

Picking the right tool, including when NOT to use Cowork

MEET THE NEW KID

Microsoft Scout: the always-on autopilot



Personal to you

Grounded in your role, priorities, and preferences. Learns and adapts to you over time. Runs on your desktop



Always-on proactivity

Continuously learns to anticipate your needs and take action across your M365 surface, local files, and web browser



Enterprise-ready

Built with enterprise grade governance, security, and compliance.

Scout is an always-on autopilot agent that takes action, without need to be prompted each time

You kick it off or it never stops

Both take real action. What differs is who starts the work and whether it ever ends.

REACH FOR COWORK · a job you delegate

- “Prep me for my 2pm” → calendar, emails, docs, then a brief
- Triage my inbox and draft the top 5 replies
- Read the 20 contracts in this folder and table the renewals
- Research 3 competitors, write a brief, and build the deck
- Every Friday look up what I worked on and send my boss a report

The tell — a bounded job you kick off or schedule, with a start and a finish.

REACH FOR SCOUT · an always-on autopilot

- Keep my calendar optimized — conflicts resolved, focus protected
- Watch for stalled decisions and nudge me with next steps
- Surface what needs my attention each morning, before I ask
- Track Project X and flag risks as they emerge, day after day

The tell — ongoing and proactive, it comes to you. No prompt.

Same DNA — both act on your behalf. The difference: Cowork waits for your “go.” Scout just goes.

Microsoft 365 Copilot: what to use and when?

The same task often works in multiple tools. Here are example tasks with a view of the right tool for the job.

Simpler and faster

More autonomous

TASK OR NEED	M365 COPILOT	COPILOT COWORK	MICROSOFT SCOUT*
Brainstorm ideas and find info	★	✓	✓
Catch up on emails or meetings	★	✓	✓
Create and edit artifacts e.g., Excel, Word doc, PPT, emails	★	✓	✓
Deep research and analysis	★	✓	✓
Multi-artifact creation in one job		★	✓
Multi-step business process across systems		★	✓
Always-on manage and coordinate my day			★

★ Core job ✓ Capability



Max out M365 Copilot first

Copilot Cowork is useful but don't overlook what M365 Copilot can do and get the full value of that first

M365 Copilot

included in your license

Flat monthly per user license cost

- Make it your default, all day long
- Handles the vast majority of tasks
- In the flow of Word, Excel, Outlook, Teams
- Great for single-step, single-app work

Copilot Cowork

pay-as-you-go credits

Costs credits every run (~\$0.01 each)

- Worth it for multi-step, cross-app jobs
- Worth it for bulk work across many files
- Worth it for scheduled automation
- Worth it when it saves you real time

Rule of thumb: if Copilot can do it in one step, let it. Save credits for jobs only Cowork can do.

What M365 Copilot already nails

Draft & rewrite

“Rewrite this in a friendlier tone,” “make it shorter,” “turn these notes into an email” — right inside Word and Outlook.

Analyze your data

Ask questions of an Excel sheet, add formulas, spot trends, and build a chart — all in the app.

Summarize anything

A long email thread, a 40-page document, a Teams channel, or a meeting transcript — in seconds.

Catch up & prep

“What did I miss in this chat?”, “what are the action items?”, “summarize where this project stands.”

Create files from a prompt

“Build a 10-slide deck from this Excel,” “draft a project brief,” “make a budget sheet.” Yes — Copilot creates files too.

Q&A over your files

Grounded answers from your SharePoint and OneDrive — plus shareable declarative agents for your team.

When Cowork earns its credits

It spans several apps at once

One instruction that touches email + files + Teams + calendar together — “prep me for my 2pm” pulls from all four.

One ask → a full deliverable

“Research 3 competitors, write a brief, build a deck, and email it to my team.” Many steps, many outputs, one prompt.

It's bulk work across many files

“Read these 25 contracts and build a table of renewal dates.” Reading and reasoning over a whole folder.

It acts on the open web

File an expense report on a website or book travel — browser tasks M365 Copilot can't touch.

It runs on a schedule

“Every weekday at 8am, send me a briefing.” Recurring automation that runs in the cloud without you.

You'd otherwise do it by hand

Weigh a few cents of credits against 30 minutes of app-switching — and what you'd rather do with that time. Time = money.

TIME = MONEY

“I could do it in Copilot” isn’t the whole question

Yes, M365 Copilot plus a few manual steps can get there. But what is your time worth and what would you do with the half hour back?

The manual way

M365 Copilot + you

Prompt in Copilot Chat, then switch to Teams

- Copy-paste between apps, hunt for files
- Re-prompt at each step, stitch it together
- ~30 minutes of your focus — gone
- ...and again every time you repeat it

The Cowork way

one instruction, done for you

Delegate the whole job in a single ask

- It works across the apps while you don’t
- ~2 minutes of your attention
- A few credits used
- You spend the 28 minutes saved on real work

The real question isn’t “can Copilot do it?” — it’s “is your time worth more than a few credits?”

Copilot or Cowork?

“Make this reply more concise and polite.”

M365 Copilot — one step, right in Outlook.

“Build a 10-slide deck from this quarterly Excel.”

M365 Copilot — yes, it creates files too. Don't pay credits for this.

“Every Mon 8am: brief me on inbox, calendar & Teams.”

Copilot Cowork — scheduled and cross-app.

“Table the renewal dates in these 25 contracts.”

Copilot Cowork — bulk work across many files.

“Summarize this 40-page contract a client just sent.”

M365 Copilot — one document, one step.

“Research 3 rivals, write a brief, build a deck, email it.”

Copilot Cowork — many steps, many outputs, one ask.



BREAK

15-Minute Break

Nice work — that wraps Part 1. We'll pick back up with Everyday Productivity.
Back in 15 minutes (watch the chat for the exact return time). Grab a coffee and stretch.

04

Everyday Productivity with Cowork

Real-world workflows that save hours every week

Have a Great Cowork Conversation

1

Start With the End

“Email Sarah about the Q2 review tomorrow at 2pm” beats “send that email”

2

Set the Stage

Give the goal and background a new teammate would need — role, audience, why

3

Point to the Sources

Name the files, people, or date range to use and the format you want back

4

Watch, Then Approve

Track the live progress; review previews before it sends, posts, or schedules

5

Iterate in the Thread

Treat the first result as a draft — “tighten it,” “add a blockers section”

Cross-App Workflows

The real power is connecting actions across apps in one conversation



Check
Email



Find
Document



Summarize
Content



Post to
Teams



Schedule
Follow-Up

This is what makes Cowork a coworker, not just a tool.

A single conversation can span your entire M365 environment — reading emails, finding files in SharePoint, posting to Teams, and scheduling meetings — all without you switching apps.

Email & Inbox Management



Let Cowork handle your inbox so you can focus on what matters

Triage by Priority

Sort unread messages by urgency and importance

Summarize Threads

Get the key points from long email chains

Draft Replies

Write responses in your voice for quick acknowledgments

Cross-App Search

Search across email and Teams together

Try: "Go through my unread emails, flag anything urgent, and draft replies to the quick ones"

Meeting Prep & Intelligence

Before the Meeting

- Pull attendee context and roles
- Find relevant emails and docs
- Summarize past meeting notes
- Surface open action items

After the Meeting

- Summarize transcript highlights
- Extract action items and owners
- List decisions that were made
- Draft and send follow-up email

Try: "Prep me for my 1:1 with [manager] — what did we discuss last time and what's pending?"

Calendar Management



Your calendar, optimized — conflicts resolved, focus time protected

Schedule Review

Analyze your week for conflicts, overload, and gaps

Smart Decline

Suggest which invitations to decline with context

Focus Blocks

Automatically block focus time around your priorities

Batch Actions

Accept, decline, or tentatively accept multiple invitations

Try: "Review my calendar for next week — flag conflicts, suggest what to decline, block focus time"

Research & Document Creation



From research to finished deliverable — all in one conversation

Deep Research

Web search with citations and source verification

Word Documents

Reports, memos, and briefs with professional formatting

Slide Decks

PowerPoint presentations from topic to finished slides

Spreadsheets

Excel files with data, formulas, and charts

Try: "Research [topic], create a summary doc with sources, and draft a slide deck for my team"

Rebalance your week and protect focus time

Goal: Take control of a fragmented calendar before it takes control of your week.

Outcome: A rebalanced schedule that protects focus time, prioritizes high-impact meetings, and resolves conflicts — without manually negotiating your own availability.

Prompt

Help me organize my week. Review my Outlook calendar.

First, show me a summary: Total meetings and hours spent, where I have focus time (2+ hours), and days with the most meetings.

Before taking changes, ask clarifying questions: my manager and management chain — note if they are on a meeting, how many attendees, what I'm trying to accomplish this week, how to prioritize conflicts, personal commitments, and which meetings to decline or shorten.

Then show proposed changes with explanations: meetings to accept/decline/reschedule, conflicts to resolve (including emailing organizers), and focus blocks to add. Start with highest-impact changes first.

Once I approve each change, make edits directly in my calendar one at a time.

Follow-up prompts: Accept and decline meetings. Create a customer meeting prep document.

Execution Workflow

Calendar → Summarize meeting load + focus time

Clarify → Weekly goals + constraints

Evaluate → Meeting impact + conflicts

Propose → Accept / decline / reschedule

Recommend → Add focus blocks

Approve → Proposed changes

Execute → Apply updates one-by-one

Note: You can schedule this to run automatically by starting your prompt with "Create a skill where this occurs every Monday morning."

Wrap up projects and organize all related work

Goal: Close out a project with a clean, shareable archive, not a scattered trail of files.

Outcome: A single OneDrive folder with the project's deliverables and references, shared with the team so the work stays findable and easy to reference.

Prompt

I just wrapped up the [Project Name] project.

Find all files in my OneDrive related to this project — docs, decks, spreadsheets.

Create a new folder called “[Project Name] — Archive” and move everything into it. Share the archive folder with the [Project Name] team so they have a clean reference.

Then build a lightweight HTML recap page for the archive — project outcomes, key contributors, links to the headline deliverables, and a one-paragraph “what shipped” summary up top — so the archive is navigable, not just a folder of files.

Execution Workflow

OneDrive → Locate project files

Classify → Docs / decks / spreadsheets

Create → Archive folder

Move → Related artifacts

Share → Archive folder

Confirm → Central project reference

Build → HTML project recap page
for the archive

Turn a document or deck into a visual framework

Goal: Take dense, written content and turn it into a clear visual the team can actually engage with — without spending the afternoon redrawing it by hand.

Outcome: A Miro visual — flowchart, mindmap, or framework diagram — that translates the source content into a clean, presentation-ready format.

Prompt

Take [document or deck name] and convert the key content into a Miro visual — either a process flowchart, mindmap, or structured framework diagram depending on what fits the content best.

Use frames, shapes, and text to keep it clean and presentation-ready.

Execution Workflow

Source → Read full document or deck

Identify → Core structure + relationships

Select → Best-fit visual format

Map → Content to shapes + frames

Miro → Build visual layout

Refine → Clean, presentation-ready output

Catch up on messages and send replies automatically

Goal: Close the loop on unanswered questions without scrolling back through a week of threads.

Outcome: Routine acknowledgments handled automatically, higher-stakes replies drafted for review — so you stay responsive without spending hours catching up.

Prompt

Go through my Teams messages and emails from this week where someone asked me a direct question and I haven't responded.

For anything that just needs a quick acknowledgment or "got it," send the reply. For anything that needs a real answer, draft it and show me first.

Execution Workflow

Email + Teams → Scan weekly conversations

Detect → Direct questions without response

Classify → Acknowledgment vs. substantive reply

Generate → Quick acknowledgment responses

Draft → Substantive replies for review

Auto-send → Low-risk acknowledgments

Surface → Drafted replies for approval

Generate and send your weekly status automatically

Goal: Replace the Monday-morning scramble with a status update that writes itself.

Outcome: A ready-to-send weekly status, drafted from your real meetings and conversations, that lands in your team's inbox to start the week.

Prompt

I create a weekly email to my team focused on my top of mind for the week — I send this Monday morning and it includes my top of mind as well as some of the key meetings for the week.

Those key meetings tend to be executives and my top of mind are related to the key priorities and projects the team and I are working on.

Pull a few key metrics from Fabric tied to our priorities — progress since last week — and weave them into the update so the status is grounded in real numbers.

Create a skill where this occurs every Monday morning.

Execution Workflow

Calendar → Identify key meetings

Email → Extract top-of-mind priorities

Teams → Capture project updates

Fabric IQ → Pull priority metrics + weekly progress

Summarize → Draft weekly status

Validate → Highlight exec-level meetings

Approve → Review draft

Schedule → Send every Monday morning

Turn inbox noise into a curated intelligence brief

Goal: Cut through a week of newsletters to the stories that actually matter to your work.

Outcome: A curated weekly brief that surfaces meaningful trends across the publications you follow — without the time spent reading them.

Prompt

Search my inbox for all newsletters, digests, and industry publications received in the past 7 days.

Then write a polished, article-style weekly brief covering four sections: (1) [Company] internal newsletters, (2) AI & tech news, (3) World affairs/news publications, and (4) [Your industry] — weaving the key stories and themes from each into flowing narrative paragraphs, not bullet lists.

Exclude personal or consumer newsletters (hardware, food bank fundraisers, etc.).

End with a 2–3 sentence throughline tying the week's themes together. Write the output inline as a readable article. Include links inline to the actual emails in case I want to read more.

Then, as a Part 2, pick the top headline stories across the brief and run a deep research report on them — pull the primary sources behind each, summarize the substance, and surface the context, key data points, and “so what” for my work. Deliver this as a separate research companion to the brief.

Send me this weekly brief every Friday afternoon.

Execution Workflow

Inbox → Identify newsletters + digests

Categorize → Internal / AI / news / industry

Filter → Exclude consumer content

Synthesize → Narrative brief

Compile → Inline article

Link → Source emails

Research → Deep dive on top headlines

Send → Every Friday afternoon



Prepare a complete out-of-office handoff

Goal: Step away from your laptop knowing nothing in flight will stall while you are out.

Outcome: A handover document built from your real work — projects, owners, deadlines, and supporting files — so coverage stays clear and execution keeps moving.

Prompt

I am about to go out of office for x week(s) beginning this coming [date]. Build an out-of-office tracker to cover off on all ongoing projects and tasks that will require things to move forward while I am gone.

This should cover all team meetings from this week, all emails, and all Teams messages (both in meeting chats, individual chats, and group chats). Please also analyze my calendar for next week, and any projects that have action items for next week and include these in the handover. This should cover big project asks as well as smaller project tasks.

Please limit the team members who are covering to my internal team members.

For this handover, include: Project name, Project Status, Upcoming next steps & deadlines, Action items that need to be done, Who should cover it while I am out, and links to any relevant documents.

Then act on my calendar for the OOO window: set my out-of-office auto-reply, decline or delegate non-critical meetings I'm invited to, and flag any meetings I own that should be rescheduled or covered. Hold all calendar changes for my review.

Execution Workflow

Meetings (this week) → Identify active projects + stakeholders

Email threads → Extract open requests + dependencies

Teams chats → Capture in-flight tasks

Calendar (next week) → Detect upcoming deadlines

Org directory → Match internal team coverage

Files → Link supporting documents

Compile → Ownership-assigned handover tracker

Calendar → Set auto-reply, decline/ delegate meetings, flag owned meetings

Analyze and optimize your OneDrive at scale

Goal: Turn a sprawling OneDrive into a structured catalog you can actually act on.

Outcome: An organization plan and visual overview of your files — with cleanup decisions queued up for your approval.

Prompt

Analyze my OneDrive. Catalog and categorize all of the files.

Create a dynamic HTML presentation showing the disposition of the files, age, relevancy, customer, product etc. The presentation should be no more than five scrolling screens with an executive overview with animated interactivity. The sixth screen should be recommendations.

Create a plan to optimize my files and reorganize them. The plan should include folders and files to delete which you will rename by prepending the original name with "Delete_" and place them all into a Delete folder.

Present me with your plan before you act on it.

Execution Workflow

OneDrive → Scan file inventory

Catalog → Age + relevance

Categorize → Customer / product

Visualize → HTML dashboard

Recommend → Optimization plan

Rename → "Delete_" files

Approve → Re-org actions

Build your executive command center

Goal: Start every day knowing exactly where to focus — without scrolling through emails, meetings, and chats to triangulate it yourself.

Outcome: A personal, interactive HTML command center that surfaces what needs your attention this week, where your time is going, and one or two prescriptive recommendations grounded in real signal patterns.

Prompt

Create an interactive HTML dashboard titled “Executive Command Center” that shows me what needs my attention today and this week, based on my work patterns, communications, priorities, and business performance metrics.

Include:

- Header bar with current week context and an urgent action banner
- 1–2 high-priority alerts with clear calls to action
- Three situational tiles: Today’s next priority · Busiest Day · Work Days Left
- Key business metrics from Fabric as a business-health strip — show current value, trend, and flag anything off-target
- Tabbed view for Meetings, Priorities, and Org Pulse
- A 30-day interaction map showing who I work with most and how often
- Prescriptive recommendations labeled “Dial Up,” “Dial Down,” or “Re-engage” — each tied to a specific person or workstream with a clear recommended action

Design: Clean, executive-ready, built around the question “What should I do differently today?”

Execution Workflow

Calendar + Email + Teams → Map weekly load and signals

Fabric IQ → Pull business metrics and KPIs

Detect → Urgent items, conflicts, overdue threads

Cluster → People interaction patterns

Recommend → Dial up / dial down / re-engage

Build → Interactive HTML dashboard

Surface → Single-page artifact for daily use

Audit and surface against a standard

Goal: Apply a brand guide, naming convention, compliance policy, or quality standard across dozens of files — without manually reviewing each one and without risking accidental changes.

Outcome: A sortable audit report showing every violation, its severity, and a recommended fix — so you can prioritize manual cleanup confidently.

Prompt

Audit every [file / image / asset / document] in [folder] against [our standard / brand guidelines / compliance policy / naming convention]. Read each one in full.

Categorize violations by severity:

- Critical
- Major
- Minor

For each violation, describe the issue, the impact, and a specific recommended fix.

Produce a sortable Excel report showing total items reviewed, violations by category, the most common issues, and the recommended order to address them.

Don't change any files — give me the action list.

Execution Workflow

Folder → Read every item in full

Compare → Each item against the standard

Categorize → Violations by severity

Describe → Issue · impact · recommended fix

Compile → Sortable audit report

Surface → Prioritized action list

Note: This task pairs bulk reading with safety — Cowork doesn't change any files. It surfaces a complete action list so you can prioritize manual cleanup.

Automate recurring project reporting

Goal: Replace the manual “pull the board, write the update, send it out” Monday-morning cycle with a status update that writes and sends itself.

Outcome: A recurring stakeholder update — drafted from real board data and delivered on cadence — so progress, risks, and deadlines stay visible without anyone chasing them.

Prompt

Set up a recurring bi-weekly status update for [project name] that pulls from my [Monday.com board].

Each update should highlight: Overall project health, tasks completed since last update, upcoming deadlines in the next two weeks, and any blockers or risks.

Draft the update and send it to [stakeholder/distribution list] every other Monday.

Create a skill so this runs automatically.

Execution Workflow

Monday.com → Pull current board state

Compare → Changes since last update

Identify → Upcoming deadlines + risks

Summarize → Health + progress narrative

Draft → Stakeholder update email

Skill → Save as recurring workflow

Schedule → Send every other Monday

LIVE DEMO

The Morning Workflow

A realistic morning routine: inbox triage, meeting prep, calendar review, document summary, all in one Cowork session

CHALLENGE 2

The Morning Kickstart

It's Monday morning. You have a busy week ahead. Use Cowork to get fully prepped.

1. Get a briefing on your day — meetings, emails, and priorities
2. Prep for your first meeting of the day
3. Find and summarize a document relevant to your work this week
4. Draft a status update email to your manager

Bonus

Complete all four tasks in a single Cowork conversation without switching apps.

05

Build Your Own Cowork Workflows

From scheduled tasks to custom skills and plugins, make Cowork work your way

Designing Repeatable Workflows

Ask yourself these questions to find your best automation opportunities:



What tasks do you repeat daily or weekly?

Status reports, inbox triage, meeting prep



What multi-step processes could be a single request?

Research → document → email → schedule



What team workflows could be standardized?

Onboarding checklists, project kickoffs



Where do you waste time on manual coordination?

Scheduling, follow-ups, status gathering

Skills: reusable playbooks you create

WHY USE A SKILL

Maintainability

Keep the agent instructions readable, so a person can follow what it does one focused Skill at a time.

Efficient context use

Instructions load only when the scenario needs them, instead of on every single turn.

Accuracy, in some cases

A large always-on prompt makes the model weigh irrelevant guidance every turn, which can reduce accuracy. A Skill loads only what the task needs.

SKILL.md

name + description = routing metadata

Skill Instructions

the core

Examples

show, don't tell

Resources

files, templates

Scripts

executable code

Metadata sits in context by default. Full content loads only when a scenario matches.

AVOID

Vague descriptions

Weak routing signals make a Skill mis-fire or never trigger.

Mega-skills

Broad, do-everything scope blurs intent and overlaps others.

Fact dumps

A Skill guides; it does not replace a Knowledge source.

Unreviewed Skills

Treat AI or community Skills as untrusted code: review first.

A Skill is just instructions and resources, loaded on demand. Keep it scenario-specific, name it precisely, and test that it fires.

Where skills come from

Up to 50 skills; the folder name must match the skill name.

Build your own

- Get a great result, then say “save this as a skill.”
- Or write a SKILL.md by hand — it’s plain markdown.
- Lives in OneDrive ▶ Documents ▶ Cowork ▶ skills.

Microsoft-provided

- Built-in skills ship with Cowork (Word, Excel, Email, Deep Research...).
- Plugins add packaged skills from the M365 App Store.

The community

- Open Agent Skills standard — the same SKILL.md runs in Claude Code, GitHub Copilot & 30+ tools.
- Community gallery: github.com/kesslernity/awesome-copilot-cowork-skills
- Plus Microsoft’s CAT agent skills: microsoft.github.io/cat-agent-skills

A bad skill vs. a good skill

Same idea, very different results. The description is what makes Cowork pick it.

BAD SKILL

vague and bloated

name: helper

- description: “helps with stuff”
- No trigger phrases — it never fires
- Tries to do everything (a mega-skill)
- Folder name ≠ name field → won't load
- Dumps facts a Knowledge source should hold

GOOD SKILL

precise and scoped

name: friday-status

- description names the trigger: “Friday status”
- One clear job, scenario-specific
- Folder name matches the name field exactly
- Specifies sources, format, and tone
- Says what NOT to do (e.g., never auto-send)

Precise name + real trigger phrases + one job = a skill that actually runs.

Anatomy of a Skill

It's just a SKILL.md

A folder with one Markdown file: YAML frontmatter on top, plain-language instructions below. No code required.

Companion files (optional)

A references/ folder for templates or docs, and scripts for code. Up to 20 files, 10 MB total per skill.

name + description

The frontmatter. “name” is kebab-case and must match the folder. The “description” trigger phrases are how Cowork decides when to fire it.

Where it lives

OneDrive ▸ Documents ▸ Cowork ▸ skills ▸ your-skill ▸ SKILL.md.
Discovered at the start of each new conversation.

Instructions

The workflow: numbered steps, which sources to use, the output format and tone, and a “never do” list.

How many

Up to 50 personal skills, each SKILL.md up to ~1 MB. Folder name ≠ name field is the #1 reason a skill won't load.

Creating a Custom Skill

1

Identify

Pick a task you do repeatedly

2

Describe

Write how you want it done in plain language

3

Create

Tell Cowork to save it as a skill

4

Use

Run it anytime with a simple command

Example Skill: Weekly Status Report

"Gather my sent emails, completed tasks, and meeting notes from the past week. Format them into a status update using our team's template: what I accomplished, what's in progress, and what's blocked. Keep it under 300 words and use a professional but friendly tone."

Skill Design Tips

1

Be Specific About Outputs

Define the format, length, and tone you want

2

Include Your Context

Mention your role, team, and preferences

3

Specify Data Sources

Tell it which M365 sources to check

4

Set Decision Boundaries

Define when to ask you vs. make decisions

5

Test and Iterate

Skills get better as you refine them

PRO TIP

Skills don't just save time, they save credits

Turn a repeat task into a Skill and the cost drops every time you run it.

1. Do a task once, then tell Cowork: “make this a skill I can reuse.”
2. The skill captures the workflow, so future runs skip the expensive figuring-out.
3. Real example: comparing 5 CSV files into a report cost 1,700 credits the first time.
4. As a skill, each of the next dozen runs cost ~350 credits, roughly 80% less.

Measure it

Run /cost after a task to see the credits it used. Skill your expensive, repeatable tasks first — teams that do see credit usage level out.

LIVE DEMO

Save a Prompt Result as a Skill

Watch a normal prompt become a reusable skill.
Run a task, like the result, then say “save this as a skill”

CHALLENGE 3

Turn a Prompt Into a Skill

Skip the blank page and let a great result become your skill

1. Try this starter prompts in a new Cowork chat:

Review my sent email, meetings, and Teams activity from the past seven days. Draft a weekly status update with accomplishments, work in progress, blockers or risks, decisions needed, and priorities for next week. Keep it under 400 words. Use a professional but conversational tone. Do not invent accomplishments, owners, dates, or outcomes.

2. Tell Cowork “save this as a skill” — it captures the workflow, structure, and context
3. Give it a clear name and a specific description so it fires on the right words
4. Run it again on fresh data to confirm it triggers and repeats the result

Skill Recorder: Record a Task, Get a Skill

An experimental Microsoft tool, record yourself once, turn it into a skill

1. Record: hit a shortcut and do the task normally as it captures your steps, apps, and clicks
2. Analyze: it rebuilds the session into one overall intent plus an ordered list of steps to review
3. Create: approve it to generate a reusable Skill or a scheduled Automation
4. Best for fuzzy, click-heavy tasks that are hard to describe in plain words

Good to know

It's a GitHub Copilot CLI tool (github.com/microsoft/skill-recorder), not a native Cowork feature, it's an adjacent way to author skills, not something built into Cowork today.

Scheduled Tasks



Set it and forget it, recurring automations that run on your behalf

Daily Briefing

Morning summary of your inbox, calendar, and priorities delivered to you in Teams

Weekly Digest

End-of-week roundup of key emails, decisions, and action items

Recurring Reports

Status updates that gather data and format automatically

Meeting Prep

Automatic briefing before your Monday standup or weekly 1:1

Try: "Every weekday at 8am, check my inbox, review my calendar, and send me a briefing in Teams"

Scheduled tasks: how they really work

Set it up by chatting

Click Create, then answer two questions — what to run and when. Cowork drafts an editable confirmation card.

Where it runs

In the cloud, no laptop needed.

Pick a cadence

Presets: every weekday morning, daily, weekly, or monthly — or type your own (“every Friday at 4pm”).

Gotchas to know

Times can be UTC-based — double-check the “next run.” Scheduled runs use the default model (no per-run pick). Write each prompt self-contained; it has no memory of past runs.

Choose the output

Each run starts a New conversation (default) or continues the Same one. It runs a sample immediately so you see it work.

Manage & govern

Edit, pause, or delete from the Scheduled tab in Tasks. Admins can turn scheduling off org-wide via Cloud Policy.

LIVE DEMO

Scheduled Tasks in Action

Setting up a recurring Friday wrap-up that compiles the week's project updates from Teams and email, then posts a status summary, automatically, every Friday at 4pm

CHALLENGE 4

Setup a Scheduled Task

Enter a prompt and get a recurring automation

1. Put in this sample prompt in a new Cowork chat:

Every Friday afternoon, review my calendar, sent email, and Teams activity from the previous seven days. Create a draft weekly wrap-up with accomplishments, unresolved items, blockers, and next week's priorities. Start each run in a new conversation. Do not send the update automatically.

2. Watch as Cowork turns this into a scheduled task
3. Run it to test that it works

Good to know

Your scheduled tasks can call your skills so that they run more efficiently.



BREAK

15-Minute Break

That's Part 2 done. Next up: Plugins, MCP, and a look at Browser Use.
Back in 15 minutes (watch the chat for the exact return time). Refill that coffee.

Extend with Skills & Plugins

Skills are personal and yours to manage. Plugins are packaged and governed by your admin.

SKILLS

personal · no admin needed

Definition

Specific instruction set

How to add?

- OOB skills created/provided by MSFT — no user action needed
- Personal skills via natural language ("Create a skill that...") or upload skill.md to OneDrive

How to manage?

- You manage yourself

PLUGINS

packaged · admin-governed

Definition

Package of functionality that gives Cowork new domain expertise by combining skills and data integrations (MCPs)

How to add?

- Built by MSFT
- Built by 3P (Adobe, Atlassian, LSEG, Miro first)
- Org custom builds
- Turn any Claude Cowork plugin into a Copilot Cowork plugin

How to manage?

- Managed like an app, admin deploys and selects who has access within tenant

Anatomy of a Plugin

One .zip package

A standard Microsoft 365 app package — the same format as Teams apps and Office add-ins.

Connectors (MCP)

Remote MCP servers for live data and APIs (HTTPS, JSON-RPC). Up to 10 per plugin — credentials stay in the Enterprise Token Store, never in the package.

manifest.json

The M365 app manifest: declares the plugin, lists its skills, and points to its connectors.

Two icons

A 192×192 color icon and a 32×32 outline icon for the app list and store.

A /skills folder

One or more SKILL.md folders — the domain expertise. Up to 20 skills per plugin.

How it ships

Sideload to test, or the admin uploads it in the M365 Admin Center; publish org-wide via the M365 App Store.

Plugin Options



D365 Customer Service

Query and manage cases, knowledge articles, support workflows



D365 Finance & Operations

Access financial data, supply chain, and ops workflows



D365 Sales

Query leads, opportunities, accounts, pipeline data



Fabric IQ

Bring Power BI and Fabric data into your Cowork workflows



+ Custom plugins

Build your own — same package format, your APIs

Options To Build a Custom Plugin

Bring in an existing Claude plugin, or build from scratch — both finish as one M365 package

A. CONVERT

Existing Claude plugin · ~5 min

Run the conversion script on your Claude plugin folder:

```
.\Convert-ClaudePluginToMOS3.ps1  
-PluginPath ./my-plugin
```

It reads plugin.json, .mcp.json and skills/, then emits a valid manifest.json and .zip. Skills copy over verbatim.

B. FROM SCRATCH

New plugin · ~30 min

Author a SKILL.md, optionally add a references/ folder and a connector, write manifest.json, add two icons, then zip it.

Best when you're starting fresh or your workflow is unique to your org.

THEN: TEST & SHIP

Same for both paths

Sideload in the M365 Admin Center: Manage Apps → Upload custom app.

Your skills appear under Cowork ▶ Sources & Skills. Publish to the Microsoft 365 App Store via Partner Center.

Prompt vs. Skill vs. Plugin vs. MCP



Four layers that build on each other inside Cowork

Prompt

A single request you type — the starting point.
“Summarize this,” “prep my 2pm.”

Skill

A saved prompt-workflow you reuse by name, so you don't re-type it — your playbook.

Plugin

A package that adds skills + data connectors for a whole domain — installed like an app.

MCP

The open protocol under plugins that lets Cowork talk to outside tools and live data.

Prompt → Skill → Plugin → MCP: each layer adds reuse and reach. MCP is what connects Cowork to the world.

What is MCP?

The “USB-C for AI”

- MCP — Model Context Protocol — is an open standard for connecting AI to tools and data.
- One common plug, so any agent can talk to any connected system.
- Backed by Anthropic, Microsoft, and 30+ tools.

What it does

- An MCP server exposes a system’s actions and data as “tools” Cowork can call.
- Live data and real actions — not just text — securely, with your permissions.

Where you see it in Cowork

- A plugin’s connectors ARE MCP servers — that’s how a plugin reaches Salesforce, SAP, or your own API.
- Credentials stay in the Microsoft Enterprise Token Store — never in the plugin.
- Same standard as Claude and GitHub Copilot — build once, use everywhere.

LIVE DEMO

Using a Plugin

Use an out-of-the-box plugin in Cowork



Cowork CLI — Copilot in Your Terminal

The same runtime, models, skills & connectors as Cowork — now scriptable

WHAT IT IS

M365 Copilot, in the shell

Talks to the same Aether runtime that powers Cowork — identical models, skills, and connectors — so results match the app.

One cross-platform install (Windows, Mac, Linux, WSL). Needs Python 3.11+; auto-updates on launch.

```
curl -fsSL \
  https://aka.ms/cowork/sh \
  | bash
```

WHEN & WHY

Scale past the web UI

Built for evals: run hundreds of prompts in parallel. It composes with bash, xargs, and Claude Code at full throughput.

```
cat prompts.txt | xargs \
  -P10 cowork send --json \
  "{}" >> out.jsonl
```

Or run it as an MCP server — expose Cowork as tools to any MCP client.

FOUR COMMANDS

The whole workflow

```
cowork auth login
cowork chat
cowork tui
cowork send "..."
```

Sign in (MSAL), open the interactive REPL, launch the full-screen TUI, or fire a single scriptable message.

send takes --json, --file and --ref email:"Q3 Budget" to attach context.

Browser Use (Preview) — Coming to Cowork

In preview and rolling out — here's what's coming, and what it needs to run



**Ask
Cowork**



**Opens
Edge Tab**



**Acts as
You (SSO)**



**Hands Off
for MFA**



**Delivers
Result**

What to know before you count on it

Browser Use is a preview feature and it's off by default — a tenant admin has to switch it on under Copilot ► Settings ► Cowork settings. When it's on, it runs in Microsoft Edge only (up to date, signed in with your work account) and only in Cowork on the web — not the desktop or mobile apps yet. It opens a hidden Edge tab, acts with your existing sign-ins, and surfaces the tab only for logins, MFA, or CAPTCHAs. It isn't reliable enough to demo today, so we're flagging it as coming rather than running the live challenge.

06

Licensing

What it costs and how to govern

How Usage-Based Licensing Works



Cowork adds pay-as-you-go credits on top of your Copilot license

License + Credits

Needs a Microsoft 365 Copilot license, then Cowork bills usage separately as Copilot Credits

\$0.01 per Credit

Pay-as-you-go, or prepaid capacity packs — e.g., \$200 for 25,000 credits per month

Metered on 4 Things

The model chosen, how much of your data it reads, tool calls made, and total runtime

Admins Set the Caps

A Cost Management dashboard sets hard spend limits and alerts by tenant, group, or user

The hidden cost is reading your data: input can run ~60x the visible output. Scope tasks to the sources they truly need.

What Does a Task Actually Cost?

Microsoft groups tasks into three tiers — know roughly where yours lands:

1. Light: 100–300 credits (~\$1–3) — a lookup, a summary, a single action
2. Medium: 300–700 credits (~\$3–7) — multiple sources, structured, a couple of outputs
3. Heavy: 700+ credits (\$7+) — deep research, large data, many outputs
4. Worth it? Multiply by frequency — a 200-credit task run 50×/month ≈ \$100/user

Pro move: /cost

Type `/cost` in any conversation to see the credits used so far (e.g., “406 credits — about \$4”). Run it before you schedule a task to repeat.

Watch the Credit Bleed

Small habits that keep a big task from becoming a big bill

1. Tell it not to over-format — Cowork loves to restyle things you didn't ask for, and that quietly burns credits
2. Don't dump huge folders into context; point it at the specific files it actually needs
3. Start on a lighter model and step up only when the task truly needs the deeper reasoning
4. Turn any repeat task into a Skill — the per-run cost drops every time you reuse it

One Power User Shouldn't Drain the Budget

Admins get spending policies for Cowork under Copilot ▶ Cost Management

1. Set a monthly budget per policy — plus an optional monthly credit ceiling per user
2. Alert admins when a user reaches 70% of their ceiling, before it becomes a surprise
3. Scope policies to security groups; track consumption by user, group, and service
4. Hit the limit and those agents pause for that user until credits reset on the 1st

Start conservative

Begin with tight limits, watch who creates real value, then raise their caps deliberately. Adoption without budget guardrails is lazy governance.

POP QUIZ

Cowork or something else?

Six quick scenarios. For each one, decide: Copilot Cowork, M365 Copilot, Copilot Studio, or Power Automate. Vote in the chat then we reveal the answer.

QUIZ 1

The Quick Rewrite

“In Word right now, rewrite this paragraph to sound more formal.”

1. A · M365 Copilot
2. B · Copilot Cowork
3. C · Copilot Studio
4. D · Power Automate

Answer

M365 Copilot — a single-step edit in the flow of work. Don't send a coworker to do a one-liner.

QUIZ 2

The Monday Briefing

“Every Monday at 8am, scan my inbox, calendar, and Teams and send me a prioritized briefing.”

1. A · M365 Copilot
2. B · Copilot Cowork
3. C · Copilot Studio
4. D · Power Automate

Answer

Copilot Cowork — a recurring, cross-app job it runs for you. This is a scheduled Cowork task.

QUIZ 3

The Customer Chatbot

"We need a website bot that answers product FAQs from our knowledge base and opens a ServiceNow ticket — for thousands of customers."

1. A · M365 Copilot
2. B · Copilot Cowork
3. C · Copilot Studio
4. D · Power Automate

Answer

Copilot Studio — a custom agent you build once and deploy to many, wired to an external system.

QUIZ 4

The Expense Report

“File my expense report on the Concur website, pulling the receipts from my email.”

1. A · M365 Copilot
2. B · Copilot Cowork
3. C · Copilot Studio
4. D · Power Automate

Answer

Copilot Cowork with Browser Use — a personal task spanning your email and an external web app in Edge.

QUIZ 5

The File Router

“When a file lands in this SharePoint folder, copy it to the archive and post to a Teams channel — every time.”

1. A · M365 Copilot
2. B · Copilot Cowork
3. C · Copilot Studio
4. D · Power Automate

Answer

Power Automate — a fixed rule with no judgment. Don't pay for AI reasoning you don't need.

QUIZ 6

The Contract Sweep

“Read these 35 vendor contracts in my OneDrive, pull each renewal date, and flag anything expiring within 90 days in a table.”

1. A · M365 Copilot
2. B · Copilot Cowork
3. C · Copilot Studio
4. D · Power Automate

Answer

Copilot Cowork — bulk reading plus reasoning into a deliverable for you.
(Team-wide & automatic? Lean Studio.)

07

Bonus Cowork Labs: Real Business Challenges

Hands-on collaborative problem-solving with realistic scenarios

The New Project Kickoff

You've just been assigned to lead a new cross-functional project.

1. Research the project topic and create a one-page briefing doc
2. Find and review relevant existing documents in SharePoint
3. Draft a kickoff meeting agenda
4. Schedule the kickoff meeting with your team
5. Send a Teams message to the project channel introducing the initiative

Deliverable

Show your completed outputs — briefing doc, meeting agenda, scheduled event, and Teams post.

The Executive Update

Your VP needs a status update by end of day.

1. Gather key updates from your email and Teams conversations this week
2. Summarize decisions and action items from recent meetings
3. Create a polished status report (Word doc or slide deck)
4. Draft an email to your VP with the report attached
5. Set up a recurring weekly version of this workflow

Deliverable

The email draft with attached status report, plus the scheduled recurring workflow.

The Inbox Zero Sprint

Your inbox has gotten out of control. Time to regain order.

1. Triage all unread emails by priority and category
2. Draft replies to the top 5 most urgent items
3. Identify emails that need follow-up and flag them
4. Summarize any long email threads into key points
5. Create a custom skill for ongoing inbox management

Deliverable

A clean inbox plan with prioritized actions, plus your custom inbox triage skill.

08

Quick tips, FAQs and resources

Names & Descriptions Do the Heavy Lifting



Cowork finds files and triggers skills on your words so make them count

Name Files Clearly

“Q3-Budget-FINAL.xlsx” is easy for Cowork to find;
“doc1” makes it guess

Skill Folder = Skill Name

A skill’s folder name must match the name inside it —
the #1 cause of skills that won’t load

Descriptions Are Triggers

The trigger phrases in a skill’s description are how
Cowork decides when to run it so be explicit

One Topic Per Thread

Start a fresh conversation for a new task so context
stays clean and credits stay down

Tip: reference a file by name — “use the Q3 Budget deck” — so Cowork grabs the right one on the first try

Trust, but Verify

Delegation works best with a light hand on the wheel

1. Ask for a changelog — 'tell me what you changed and why' — to catch misreads early
2. On synthesis tasks, require it to cite the source files so you can spot-check the claims
3. Be explicit about which account it sends or posts from — the first automated run has surprised people
4. Treat the output as a strong draft, not the final word, on anything client-facing

Approve before it acts

Sensitive actions — send, post, schedule, delete — show a preview and a risk level. Read it. It's the cheapest insurance you have.

Is It Secure? Data, Privacy & Governance



The answers IT always asks for — straight from the Microsoft docs

Your Permissions, Nothing More

Cowork inherits your access so it can only touch files and emails you already can. Sensitivity labels are shown and respected.

A Secure, Isolated Boundary

Every action is authorized through your M365 account. Claude runs as a subprocessor and no data leaves Microsoft's compliance boundary.

Admins Stay in Control

IT can disable Cowork, turn specific models on or off, govern plugins, and set spend limits per user or group.

Safe by Design

It can't delete files, can't read encrypted files, and always shows a preview before it sends, posts, or schedules.

Availability is limited to Anthropic-supported regions; some models (e.g., Claude Fable 5 Preview) require admin opt-in.

Common Complaints — and the Fix (1 of 2)

The gripes you'll hear online, and what actually solves them

1. “It burned credits fast.” → It reads a lot into context. Scope files tightly, start on a lighter model, run /cost, and set spending limits.
2. “It looked stuck / kept finalizing.” → If the step tracker is moving, it's working. Retry only after ~60s of no progress; refresh if truly frozen.
3. “It did too much / deleted things.” → Approve before it acts, forbid deletions explicitly, keep backups, and confirm which account it uses.
4. “I couldn't access X.” → Usually a permissions or momentary source issue. Check your access, see what it reached vs. couldn't, and retry shortly.

The pattern

Most complaints trace back to scope, permissions, or over-trust — all fixable with clearer instructions and a quick review step.

Common Questions – Answered (2 of 2)

The setup and “why can't I...” questions that come up most

1. “Why don't I see Cowork / my history / skills?” → It needs an M365 Copilot license plus admin enablement; some features roll out gradually, and browser use is still preview.
2. “It pulled the wrong file / wrong day.” → Be explicit: name the file and the date range
3. “It won't stop reformatting my output.” → State the exact format up front and say 'don't restyle

Still stuck?

Check Microsoft's Cowork FAQ and the admin availability checklist first — most 'it's broken' reports are really licensing or enablement.

Q&A

What questions do you have?

Keep Learning

Try our Labs

Hands-on + badges

Our guided, hands-on, self paced labs are the fastest way to go from watching this call to building your own.

aka.ms/cowork-collective

BUILD A SKILL

Developer docs

Step-by-step guidance, FAQ's and best practices on building skills.

aka.ms/cowork-skills

USE OR BUILD A PLUGIN

Developer docs

Step-by-step guidance, FAQ's and best practices on building plugins.

aka.ms/cowork-plugins

Thank You!

April Dunnam

